

The Mindfulness Workbook for Seniors Over 60 - Printable Worksheets

Every worksheet from the book, one per page, plus the ongoing logs and the breathing space card.
Print as many copies as you need.

Worksheet 0.1 - The autopilot check

For each line, how often it happens: 0 = almost never, 1 = sometimes, 2 = often, 3 = most days, 4 = several times a day. Fill it in now, and again after Week 6.

	Now	After Week 6
I finish a cup of tea and cannot remember drinking it		
I arrive somewhere on foot or by car and cannot recall the journey		
I do the jobs around the house without noticing my hands doing them		
Someone tells me their name and it is gone at once		
I eat a meal and taste only the first mouthful		
I notice tension, tiredness or pain in the body only when it has become bad		
I am thinking about the next thing while I am doing this one		
I snap at someone before I have noticed I am irritated		
I find I have been worrying for an hour without ever deciding to		
An afternoon passes and I could not say what was in it		
Total (0 to 40)		

0 to 12: mostly present, and the practice will sharpen it. 13 to 24: an ordinary busy mind, which is most of us. 25 to 40: much of the day is being spent somewhere else, and you have the most to gain. The number usually drops by a third to a half over the six weeks; it is the honest measure of what the practice is for.

Chapter 3 - Who Should Be Careful, the Check With the Doctor, and What to Do If a Practice Leaves You Worse

Who should start with a therapist, or wait.

- Anyone in a **severe depression** now (unable to get up, eat, or see any point): the treatment is the doctor and a therapist, and the mindfulness comes later, when there is enough footing to sit with the mind. MBCT is for preventing the next episode, not treating this one.
- Anyone with a **psychotic illness**, past or present, or a **bipolar** illness not currently stable: the practices can be adapted by a clinician; the book alone is not the way.
- Anyone in the **weeks after a trauma** (a death, an accident, an assault) or with a history of trauma that surfaces when things are quiet: mindfulness can help, and it can also open a door before the person is ready; the shorter, eyes-open, body-anchored practices in Week 3 are the safe starting place, and a therapist who knows trauma is the guide.
- Anyone in a **crisis**: the copyright page.

What to do if a practice leaves you worse. A small proportion of people find that sitting with the eyes closed brings up panic, dissociation (feeling unreal or far away), intrusive memories, or a flood of sadness. If that happens: open the eyes; feel the feet on the floor and the chair under you; name five things you can see; stand up and move; and do not push through. Swap the sitting practices for the walking and everyday ones for a while, keep the practices short, and if it happens more than once, talk to a doctor or therapist before going on. This is not weakness or failure; it is information, and it is why the book says "gently" so often.

The check with the doctor. Pain, sleeplessness, anxiety, low mood and a foggy memory after sixty often have a physical cause or a physical part, and mindfulness does nothing for those. The list to have checked, once, before or during the program: the thyroid; the blood count and the vitamin B12 and D; the blood sugar; the heart rhythm if the heart races or misses; the breathing if there is breathlessness; the medicines (steroids, some blood pressure and heart tablets, decongestants, sleeping tablets and their withdrawal, alcohol, caffeine); a hearing test if conversations have become hard, because hearing loss is a common and treatable cause of withdrawal and low mood; and the memory, if it is the worry, because most memory worries are attention and mood, and the few that are not are better known early.

Falls and the body. The practices in this book are done sitting in a chair, lying on the bed, standing with something to hold, or walking; nothing needs the floor unless you choose it. The body scan is done lying down and can make people drowsy: sit up slowly afterward. The mindful stretch in Week 2 is gentle and has an easier version; anyone with a new hip or knee, osteoporosis or a bad back uses the exercise books in this series for what is safe.

The rule for the whole program: curiosity, not force. If a practice is unpleasant in the ordinary way (boring, restless, the mind everywhere), that is normal and is the practice. If it is unpleasant in the way described above, stop, ground, and change tack. The difference is usually obvious.

Chapter 4 - Measuring Where You Are, and How the Program Works

Three numbers, taken before Week 1, after Week 3 and after Week 6, and every three months after, so that in six months you are looking at a change and not a memory.

1. Stress: the four questions. For each, 0 = never, 1 = almost never, 2 = sometimes, 3 = fairly often, 4 = very often, over the last month. (a) How often have you felt that you were unable to control the important things in your life? (b) How often have you felt confident about your ability to handle your personal problems? (c) How often have you felt that things were going your way? (d) How often have you felt difficulties were piling up so high that you could not overcome them? Score (a) and (d) as written; score (b) and (c) backward (0 becomes 4, 1 becomes 3, 2 stays 2, 3 becomes 1, 4 becomes 0). Add them: 0 to 16. Most adults score around 5 to 7; over 9 is a stressed month. This is the four-item Perceived Stress Scale, used in the trials.

2. The day, out of ten. At the end of the day, one number: how much of today were you actually in, rather than somewhere else in your head? 0 is none of it, 10 is all of it. Most people start at 3 or 4 and are surprised.

3. The thing you came for, out of ten. The pain, the sleep, the worry, the loneliness, the low mood: whichever it is, a number for how bad it was this week, 0 to 10. Write it beside the date. The trials measured these; so should you.

How the program works. Six weeks, one practice a week added to the ones before, ten minutes a day rising to twenty. Each week has: the idea (a page); the instructions; the practice, with its script in Appendix A to read slowly to yourself or record on your phone in your own voice, which most people prefer; a worksheet or log; a case; the things that go wrong; and what the science says about that week's practice. The weeks build: the breath is the anchor for everything after; the body scan teaches the attention to travel; the everyday practices take it out of the chair; the thoughts week is where the worry loses its grip; the feelings week is the one people say changed them; and Week 6 makes it yours.

The rules.

- Ten minutes a day beats an hour on Sunday. The same time each day, anchored to something that already happens: after the first cup of tea, before the news.
- The mind will wander; that is the practice. There is no doing it wrong except not doing it.
- A missed day is a missed day; the next day is the next day.
- Curiosity, not force (Chapter 3).
- Tick the log. The tick is the habit, and the habit is the result.

Worksheet 0.2 - The starting page

Fill this in before Week 1, in pen, and read it again in Week 6.

Why I picked this book up (the pain, the sleep, the worry, the loneliness, the wish to be more in my days)	
What I would like to be different in six weeks (one sentence, specific)	
The time and the place I will practise (after which cup of tea, in which chair)	
What has stopped me before, and what I will do about it this time	
The person I will tell , and the person who will ask me on Fridays	
My three numbers today (stress, the day, the thing)	

Worksheet 1.1 - The practice log, Week 1

Day	Sitting (minutes)	Breathing spaces (tick each)	One word for it	Notes
1		☐ ☐ ☐		
2		☐ ☐ ☐		
3		☐ ☐ ☐		
4		☐ ☐ ☐		
5		☐ ☐ ☐		
6		☐ ☐ ☐		
7		☐ ☐ ☐		

Worksheet 1.2 - The three numbers, at the start

	Date	Score
Stress (the four questions, 0 to 16)		
The day, out of ten		
The thing I came for (name it), out of ten		

Worksheet 2.1 - The practice log, Week 2

Day	Body scan (minutes)	Sitting (minutes)	Stretch (tick)	Breathing spaces	One word	Where the attention got stuck
1			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
2			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
3			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
4			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
5			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
6			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
7			☐	☐ ☐ ☐		

Worksheet 2.2 - The pain map (if pain is why you are here)

Before and after one body scan this week, shade the body outline in your mind and write it here: where the pain is, how big, what it is like (sharp, dull, hot, tight, throbbing), and a number out of ten. Then the same after.

	Where	How big (a coin, a hand, a plate)	What it is like	0 to 10
Before				
After				
Before				
After				

Worksheet 3.1 - The pleasant events calendar

Day	What was the pleasant event?	Were you aware of it while it happened?	What did the body feel?	What thoughts or feelings came with it?	What do you notice now, writing it?
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					

Worksheet 3.2 - The practice log, Week 3

Day	Sitting or scan (minutes)	Everyday activity (which)	Walk (tick)	Breathing spaces	One word
1			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
2			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
3			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
4			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
5			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
6			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
7			☐	☐ ☐ ☐	

Worksheet 4.1 - The unpleasant events calendar

Day	What was the unpleasant event?	Were you aware of it while it happened?	What did the body feel?	What thoughts came with it (the exact words)?	What do you notice now, writing it?
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					

Worksheet 4.2 - My usual thoughts

By the end of the week, the thoughts that came most often, in their own words, and the label that fits each.

The thought (the words it comes in)	Its label (worrying, remembering, judging, planning, comparing)	How often this week	What it feels like in the body

Worksheet 4.3 - The practice log, Week 4

Day	Sitting with thoughts (minutes)	Scan or stream (tick)	Breathing spaces	One word	The thought that hooked me most
1		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
2		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
3		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
4		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
5		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
6		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		
7		☐	☐ ☐ ☐		

Worksheet 5.1 - The feelings map

The feeling	Where in the body	What it feels like (tight, heavy, hot, hollow, fluttering)	What it wants me to do (avoid, ring someone, eat, argue, sleep)	What I said to it (the nurture)	What happened

Worksheet 5.2 - The practice log, Week 5

Day	RAIN (minutes)	Kindness (tick)	Sitting or scan (tick)	Breathing spaces	One word
1		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
2		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
3		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
4		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
5		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
6		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	
7		☐	☐	☐ ☐ ☐	

Worksheet 6.1 - The day of practice

Time	Practice	Minutes	One word after
	Sitting with the breath	15	
	Breathing space	3	
	Body scan	20	
	Breathing space	3	
	Mindful walk (outdoors if possible)	15	
	Mindful meal or cup of tea	15	
	Sitting with thoughts	15	
	Breathing space	3	
	Kindness practice	10	
	Sitting, and the end	10	

Worksheet 6.2 - The six-month plan

	My plan
My daily practice (which, how long)	
When and where (the anchor)	
The three moments for the breathing space	
My weekly longer practice (which day, how long)	
The practice for a bad night	
The practice for a feeling that has taken over	
The monthly check (the three numbers, first of the month)	
The two people who know I do this	
When it lapses, I will	

Worksheet 6.3 - The three numbers, at the end

	Week 1	Week 3	Week 6	3 months	6 months
Stress (0 to 16)					
The day, out of ten					
The thing I came for, out of ten					

Worksheet 6.4 - A letter to yourself, to open in six months

Write it in Week 6, seal it, date the envelope six months from today, and put it where you will find it. It is the record of what this was like from inside, for the person who will have forgotten.

Dear me, six months from now. What the six weeks were like:
What changed in the numbers, and in the days:
The one practice I most want you to have kept, and where and when you do it:
What I want you to remember if it has lapsed:
Signed, dated:

The practice log, ongoing (one month)

Day	Practice	Minutes	Breathing spaces (tick x3)	One word
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
11				
12				
13				
14				
15				
16				
17				
18				
19				

20				
21				
22				
23				
24				
25				
26				
27				
28				
29				
30				
31				

The three numbers, month by month (twelve months)

Stress score (0 to 16); the day, out of ten (average of the week); the thing you came for, out of ten.
Taken on the first of each month, written under the last.

Month	Date	Stress (0-16)	The day (0-10)	The thing (0-10)	Note
Start					
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					

The events calendar, blank (pleasant or unpleasant)

One event a day, noticed at the time, written after.

Day	What happened	What the body felt	What the mind said	Now, writing it
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

The breathing space card (to cut out and keep in a pocket)

Minute one: what is here? Thoughts (name them). Feelings (name them). The body (notice it). Let it all be here.

Minute two: the breath. All the attention on the breath. In. Out. When the mind goes, come back.

Minute three: widen. The whole body. The room. The day.

Three minutes. Three times a day. And whenever the mind has gone.

The practice on one page (to pin up)

Every day. Ten to twenty minutes, after the same cup of tea, in the same chair. The breath is the anchor. When the mind goes, and it will, notice, and come back. That is the whole exercise.

Three times a day. The breathing space: what is here; the breath; widen. Three minutes. And whenever the mind has gone.

When there is pain. The body scan; turn toward it for a breath, then move on to the parts that are well.

When a thought has hooked you. Name it: "worrying", "planning", "judging". Back to the breath. A thought is an event, not an order.

When a feeling has taken over. RAIN: Recognise it, Allow it, Investigate it in the body, Nurture with a hand and a kind word.

When you cannot sleep. The body scan in bed. If the mind will not stop, the chair, and the three o'clock sitting.

When it lapses. It will. The practice is the return, the next day, at three minutes if that is what there is.

The numbers. The first of the month: stress, the day out of ten, the thing you came for.

Curiosity, not force. A missed day is a missed day. The tick is the habit, and the habit is the result.